



■ **VIKRAM MEHRA**
CHIEF MARKETING OFFICER, TATA SKY

Incorporated in 2004, Tata Sky is a joint venture between TATA and STAR. It endeavours to offer Indian viewers a world-class TV viewing experience through its satellite TV service.

Vikram Mehra, chief marketing officer of Tata Sky, was recently in Delhi and shared with Uma Bansal, deputy editor at EFM, the current state of DTH TV in India and some suggestions for the consumers. Excerpts

larger subscriber base within this short span of time. This shows DTH is growing faster than CAS.

What's the difference between MPEG-2 and MPEG-4? What are the advantages of using the latter? Apart from the number of channels, is there any effect on the picture quality?

MPEG-2 and MPEG-4 are compression technologies that have nothing to do with the picture and sound quality. The number of channels depends on the combination of the compression technology and the number of transponders. Tata Sky has the maximum number (twelve) of transponders, so even with MPEG-2 we are able to offer every popular channel available in India.

The choice between MPEG-2 and MPEG-4 is totally a company's internal decision and it doesn't have to do anything with the consumer. The Advertising Standard Council

“MPEG-4 has nothing to do with picture and sound quality”

What's the total DTH TV subscriber base in India? Your share out of this?

India has a DTH TV subscriber base of 20-21 million. As of March 2010, we have crossed five million connections. On the value front, we are the leading player. The total number of DTH TV subscribers in India is expected to more than double in three years (by the end of 2012) to touch 45 million.

How does DTH TV compare with CAS cable TV?

According to Media Partner Associates (MPA), the total number of digital cable (CAS) homes is only two million, though this technology has been existing for long. In comparison, DTH is only 3-4.5 years old but has notched a much

of India (ASCII) in a written ruling has upheld Tata Sky's claim that Airtel's advertisement of "MPEG-4 leads to better picture quality" is a false claim.

With DTH, one has to change the STB and the antenna when one changes the service provider. What's being done to address this problem?

DTH guidelines say that the STBs should be interoperable. Our STBs are fully interoperable with those of other MPEG-2 DTH TV providers. The same dish can be used but it has to be repointed.

Can a single set of STB-antenna serve two or more TVs in a household? If not, what is required to minimise the